

On the Theological Virtues (On Faith) — Disputation VIII, Section IV nn. 65–67 and Section V entire

Juan Martínez de Ripalda, S.J. — first published posthumously (1652); text from the Vivès edition, Paris 1873, Vol. VII, printed pp. 151–156 (English translation)

A. Disputation VIII, Section IV, nn. 65–67

{p. 152}

1. Therefore to the objection made I respond: Revelations enunciating a predicate of a common subject — of which it cannot be established for us in the singular whether it has in reality been furnished with the condition necessary for the revealed predicate to belong to it — are regularly conditioned on the part of the object: as, that everyone truly contrite or duly baptized is justified; that everyone gravely sinning is deprived of justifying grace; that everyone persevering in grace up to the last end of life is crowned with heavenly beatitude; that under every consecrated host Christ is contained; and others like these. Wherefore the revelations of themselves do not claim absolute faith of the predicate's belonging to the subject, but only a conditioned faith — if the host shall have been consecrated, if the man is truly contrite, or persevering in grace, etc. Nevertheless, there can be absolute faith of the object if the conditioned truth passes into an absolute one and is sufficiently proposed to us as being absolute. Three propositions, therefore, are to be proved separately and briefly.
2. The first is that revelations of this kind are conditioned. First, because a conditioned revelation is one which enunciates its object as future in dependence upon some condition about which it enunciates nothing as future. But the universal revelations of which we treat are of this kind; because they enunciate future justification in dependence upon contrition and Baptism, glory in dependence upon perseverance in grace, privation of grace in dependence upon actual sin, the presence of Christ under the host in dependence upon consecration — without anything's being asserted as absolutely future concerning the condition upon which the object is asserted to depend; for otherwise the very absolute existence of the condition would be credible by faith, and, when sufficiently proposed, could not be denied without detriment to the faith — which no theologian will admit. Secondly, because under those universal revelations are comprehended not only subjects which in reality and absolutely are in effect furnished with the necessary condition, but also others which absolutely do not partake of the condition; since it is true, in virtue of such a revelation, that the reprobate who does not persevere in grace would be saved if he in reality persevered, and that the just man who could sin and does not sin gravely would be stripped of the habit of grace if he sinned — without a new revelation's being needed for the truth of that event. Yet subjects of this kind

cannot be comprehended under that revelation absolutely, but under a condition, because the revealed predicate does not belong to them absolutely, since the condition necessary for its truth fails them absolutely. The second proposition is easy to prove, namely, that conditioned revelations do not claim absolute faith of the object, because they claim only faith of the truth which they reveal. But the revealed truth is not absolute, but only conditioned. The third also is well established, namely, that there can be absolute faith of the object when it shall have been sufficiently established that the condition exists absolutely, and hence that the conditioned truth exists as absolute. For the absolute truth is altogether indistinct from the conditioned, and the absolute cannot be denied without the conditioned's being denied. For if it be denied that Peter, absolutely sinning, is stripped of the habit of grace, by that very fact it is denied that he would be stripped of the habit if he should have sinned; nor can the conditioned stripping of grace stand as true if the absolute is not true, when Peter is absolutely guilty of sin.

3. Therefore, when the condition necessary for the revealed predicate to belong to the object exists absolutely, it is absolutely credible by faith that such a predicate belongs in the singular subject, because the object of the judgment by which we enunciate such a predicate absolutely of the subject is in reality true from divine revelation: yet it is not absolutely credible by faith to all the faithful, but only under a condition — even though the sense of the revelation be explicitly known to all — because the existing condition under which the revelation enunciates it to be true that the predicate belongs to the subject is not absolutely known to all. Wherefore it can happen that one of the faithful can believe and enunciate the revealed predicate of the singular subject by absolute faith, without being able to deny it apart from infidelity, while others cannot believe it by absolute faith and can deny it without infidelity; because to one it can be evidently known that the condition under which the singular subject is comprehended by the common revelation exists absolutely, while to others this is unknown. For if Peter evidently

{p. 153}

knows that he has, out of malice and with full advertence, violated a grave precept, and that he is thereby guilty of grave sin, he can believe by faith that he is deprived of justifying grace, and cannot without infidelity judge that he is justified; likewise I can believe by absolute faith that this little child baptized by me is justified, because I can evidently know that he duly received Baptism, since it can be evidently known to me that I pronounced the words of Baptism, and washed him with natural water, and that a right intention of baptizing was present; and with this knowledge I cannot disbelieve his justification. Because the universal revelation asserting that everyone guilty of grave sin is stripped of the habit of grace, and that everyone duly baptized is justified, proposes it as absolutely true that I am not justified, and that the little child baptized by me is justified; because it is proposed as evidently true that I am guilty of sin, and that the child was duly baptized. Wherefore

if I were to deny this, I should necessarily judge the common revelation to be false, and should openly contradict it. But others, who are devoid of that knowledge, cannot believe it, and can absolutely disbelieve it; because to them the object asserted by the universal revelation is not proposed, as it is to me, as sufficiently credible by absolute faith.

B. Disputation VIII, Section V (nn. 68–80)

{p. 153}

SECTION V.

Whether moral evidence alone, or mere probability, suffices for singulars to be believed by absolute faith?

1. The foregoing discourse was of singulars evidently known, with evidence at least physical. That to come is of singulars known with evidence only moral, or with physical probability: whether, on account of the common revelation, they can be believed by absolute faith, although it can be physically doubted, or held in misgiving, whether they are comprehended under it? We therefore suppose two things. The one is, that the universal revelation is evidently credible to us. The other, that the singulars comprehended under it are in reality revealed by God, and pertain to the faith, and are moreover credible to us when it shall have been sufficiently established that they are comprehended under the common revelation. But the question is whether, for that proposal, moral evidence alone, or mere probability, suffices, whereby we may know that the universal revelation contains this or that singular subject, not only under a condition, but also absolutely, because the condition under which the common object is revealed is absolutely proposed as existing? — e.g., whether we can believe by absolute divine faith that this boy is justified, or this adult blessed, when this boy is proposed as duly baptized, or this adult as having died with grace, by such arguments as suffice for moral evidence, or at least for physical probability?
2. We see, disp. xii, sect. 2, that there are several degrees of moral evidence, by which this question could be confounded in words. Wherefore, that the matter of which we treat may be settled, we now suppose that the moral evidence called into examination is that which excludes not only doubt, but also prudent misgiving, although it may admit a physical one — which only physical evidence can banish. That is, because its arguments are so many and so great that, by reason of the difficulty of dissenting, no one — at least no prudent man — has ever dissented, although he could physically have dissented: as, that there really is a city of Rome and a kingdom of France, which we have never seen; because it is morally impossible that so many and so great testimonies should have agreed in the assertion of the same thing together with falsity or lying of the witnesses. This supposed, we ask two things: the one, whether this moral evidence suffices for faith of singulars resting upon the common

revelation; the other, whether, in the absence of physical evidence, it is necessary — so that mere probability, capable of doubt and misgiving, does not suffice.

3. I assert first: the aforesaid moral evidence suffices for absolute faith of singulars under a common revelation; so Lugo {marg. *Lugo. / Hurtadus, / Suarius. / Bellarm.*}, disputation I, num. 313, and Hurtadus, disputation XI, section 3, § 25, with Suarez, Bellarmine, and others. First, because if God revealed that all the cities of France were to be destroyed within a year, we could believe by divine faith that Paris is to be destroyed, though we know only by moral evidence that it is a French city. Secondly, because by divine faith we believe the authority of the Council of Trent, for which it is necessary that it be proposed to us as legitimately assembled, because God revealed only the future assistance of the Holy Spirit to councils of the Church legitimately assembled. Yet that the Council of Trent was legitimately assembled is not evident with physical evidence, but only with moral. Thirdly, a priori: because, in order that we may believe

{p. 154}

the absolute existence of the revelation, moral evidence alone suffices. Therefore, in order that we may believe that the revelation enunciates the predicate of this singular subject, the same moral evidence likewise suffices. Because no greater certitude and evidence is required for the credibility of the subject of which the revelation enunciates, than for the credibility of the revelation itself by faith.

1. I assert secondly: Moral evidence is necessary, and physical probability alone does not suffice for faith of a singular subject, if for faith of the revelation itself its evident credibility is necessary; but otherwise, if evident credibility of the revelation is not necessary, but a merely probable one suffices for the revelation's — whereby the revelation's — faith [translator's note: the printed clause, "sed sufficit solum probabilis ad revelationis, qua revelationis fidem," is apparently corrupt (see sic-note 6); the apparent sense is "but a merely probable one suffices for faith of the revelation"]. For we believe the subject of the revelation with the same certitude with which we believe the revelation. Therefore the same arguments are necessary, and suffice, for believing the subject of the revelation, which are necessary, and suffice, for believing the revelation itself. But what arguments are necessary and suffice for believing the existence of the revelation, we have examined, disp. vi, sect. 5 et seqq. Wherefore, since we there determined, with many theologians, that for faith of the revelation evident credibility is not necessary, but that a probable one alone suffices, it seems consequent that, for faith also of the singular object of which the revelation enunciates, probable credibility suffices, and the evident is not necessary.
2. Lugo, above, n. 322 et seqq., judges the opposite. First: because for faith of the revelation evident credibility is required. Secondly: because the Council of Trent, sess. vi, c. 9, denies

that anyone can believe of faith that he is in the state of grace, in these words: « For as no pious man ought to doubt of the mercy of God, of the merit of Christ, and of the virtue and efficacy of the sacraments; so each one, while he regards himself and his own infirmity and indisposition, can have misgiving and fear concerning his own grace: since no one can know, with a certainty of faith under which nothing false can lie, that he has obtained the grace of God. » From these words it seems to be gathered that probability of the universal revelation, as applied to some singular, does not suffice, if that singular is to be capable of being believed by faith. For no one can deny that some just men can have, commonly speaking, great probability concerning their grace, and that they have received the sacraments with due disposition. Yet these, without a special revelation, cannot believe by faith that they are in the state of grace, but can, and ought, prudently to have misgiving about their state. Therefore the universal revelation, that all who are truly contrite and have confessed receive grace, does not suffice for anyone — mere probability standing concerning his own contrition and due disposition — to be able to believe by faith that he has been comprehended by that universal revelation. Where at the same time you see how the Council, from the fact that each one can prudently have misgiving concerning his own justification, infers that it cannot be believed by divine faith — which is the reason adduced by Lugo.

3. These objections are easily dissolved, and are urged with little consistency with the other things which Lugo teaches. To the first I respond by denying that evident credibility is required for faith of the revelation, as from disp. vi, sect. 6 and 7, we suppose. Further, Lugo, disp. i, num. 239 et seqq., teaches that private revelations can be believed by an assent elicited from the habit of faith without evident credibility, but with only probable. But the assent of singulars elicited from the habit of faith, which we admit without evident credibility, is not of public and universal faith, but of private and particular; because its proposal is not public, and made by the authority of the Church, but by private arguments and motives of the existence of the singular subject, or of the absolute condition under which the universal object is revealed. Wherefore that assent is not altogether perfect and firm, excluding all misgiving; just as neither is the assent of a private revelation, which Lugo admits, altogether perfect and firm.
4. To the second I respond: The Council of Trent expressly denies that a man can believe himself to be justified with a certitude of faith which excludes all doubt and misgiving, but not by an imperfect and infirm faith, which can consist together with such doubt and misgiving, as is clear from the very words objected: « Each one, while he regards himself and his own infirmity and disposition, can have misgiving and fear concerning his own grace: since no one can know with the certainty of faith, etc. » But, as Lugo teaches above, there can be a faith elicited from the infused habit of faith so imperfect and infirm that it does not exclude misgiving, because there precedes not evident, but only probable credibility — such as is sometimes accorded to private revelations, which do not pertain to the Catholic and universal faith of the Church. And of this kind is the faith of singulars elicited from the habit

of faith and proceeding from only probable credibility, which we admit; with which nevertheless it can stand

{p. 155}

that that faith is certain with intrinsic certitude, under which nothing false can lie, because it is supernatural, and could not come to be in a case in which the proposition of the object were in reality false; and therefore we deny it only the extrinsic certitude proceeding from the command of the will, which shakes off all doubt and misgiving — which certitude we have shown, disp. xv, to be different and separable from the intrinsic certitude of faith. See, in confirmation and explication of this assertion, what we have set forth, disput. vi, sect. 6 and 7, and also disp. xv, sect. 2.

1. In confirmation of the same thing comes what Koninck {marg. *Koninck. / Lugo.*}, disp. xix, num. 121 et seqq., and Lugo, disp. xx, n. § 9 et seqq., teach: that there can be believed by divine faith some sense of a sacred testimony which is not received by all Catholic interpreters, but is rejected by many, and the opposite commonly thought probable — if it be in reality true and conformed to the divine mind. For then the sense believed by faith is liable to prudent misgiving, for which there suffices the judgment of the other, contradicting interpreters, together with the obscurity of the matter and the weakness and deceivability of human wit, so that one can prudently have misgiving that he has not attained the true sense of sacred Scripture — just as the Council of Trent judges that the judgment of one's own infirmity suffices for a man to be able prudently to have misgiving that he has not attained the grace of God.
2. Therefore, as even Lugo admits, disp. i, n. 302 and 323, the objective truth of the assent by which a just man believes, on probable and prudent grounds, that he is in the state of grace, is credible by faith absolutely and on the part of the object, and moreover certain with the objective certitude of faith, because it is in reality contained under the common revelation enunciating that every man truly contrite, or attrite with the sacrament, is justified: in which Lugo agrees with us. We add, however, apart from Lugo, that it is also credible to us by a formal faith, imperfect and infirm, elicited from the infused habit of faith — such as Lugo himself admits to be possible; because, as all acts of charity are not perfect and efficacious above all things, so neither must all acts of faith necessarily be perfect and above all things most firm; and hence, although all are certain with the intrinsic certitude by which they are connected with the truth of the object, they need not be certain with an every-way extrinsic certitude, whereby from the command of the will they should adhere to the object above all things and shake off all misgiving; because it suffices that they be commanded by an honest and prudent effect; and in order that the effect commanding an imperfect and infirm assent of faith be honest and prudent, probability suffices, as we have more fully expounded, disp. vi.

3. Wherefore that singular truth, contained only probably under the divine revelation, is not of faith in such wise that we are absolutely obliged to believe it, because the opposite probability suffices to take away an obligation of that kind. Supposing, however, a probable judgment concerning the condition as absolutely existing — namely, concerning true contrition, or true supernatural attrition conjoined with the sacrament — we are bound not to dissent from it; but not so, supposing only a probable apprehension of such a condition: because, supposing such a probable judgment, we cannot deny the proposition which asserts that a man truly contrite, or attrite with the sacrament, is justified, because assent to that revelation would be incompatible with such dissent. Likewise, that truth can absolutely and simply be denied to be of « faith » according to common usage, and consequently its assent also to be absolutely and simply « of faith »; because according to common usage the truth and assent of faith absolutely and simply pertain to the catholic and universal faith — to which that truth does not pertain, nor that assent, since it is not proposed by the Church, nor credible to all the faithful.
4. From these things you will gather that it can be believed by a faith elicited from the infused habit, though imperfect and infirm, that this host contains Christ, that this little child is justified, that this man is stripped of the habit of grace, and that that man is blessed. Because by prudent and probable arguments it can be proposed that those singular subjects are absolutely comprehended under the common revelation; because it can be probable and prudently credible that this host has been consecrated, that this little child has been duly baptized, that that adult is a sinner, and that that other has died in grace — which are the conditions under which God revealed the presence of Christ in the Eucharist, the justification of Baptism, the privation of grace, and the future possession of glory.
5. Finally, you will find that it can be believed by imperfect and infirm faith that this man is the true Pope and Vicar of Christ, even though his legitimate election be doubted, if there are probable and prudent arguments for the legitimate election — because God revealed that every man legitimately elected, and accepted by the Church as vicar of Christ and successor of Peter, is the true Pontiff of the Church

{p. 156}

and vicar of Christ. But if there can be no doubt, nor prudent misgiving, concerning the legitimate election, then, with the common consensus of the whole Church, the singular man can be believed to be true Pope and vicar of Christ with a faith even most firm — and not only private, but also public and catholic — because this singular subject's being contained under the common revelation is proposed as evidently credible by moral evidence banishing prudent misgiving and obliging all the faithful of the Church. And this suffices for a most firm and catholic faith to be capable of being given to this singular subject. For if it were established, by moral evidence dislodging all misgiving, that Peter is truly contrite, we could most firmly believe that he is justified. Likewise, if that

evidence were common and constant to all the faithful and to the universal Church, such faith would be catholic. Therefore, where moral evidence is present, and is common to the Church, of the legitimate election of this man as successor of Peter and Vicar of Christ, there can be present a most firm and catholic faith of the authority revealed by God under such a condition. For, for a certain and firm faith of the singular subject, common to all the faithful, the same credibility suffices which is sufficient for a certain and firm faith, universal to all the faithful, of the common revelation itself. It is confirmed: because in virtue of the common revelation it can be certainly believed, under a condition, that this man is the true Pope, if he has been legitimately elected and received by the whole Church. Therefore it can be believed absolutely that he is true Pope, when the existing condition of such a dignity revealed by God is absolutely established by moral evidence sufficient for the absolute and firm credibility of the revelation itself. These inferences are knit to the foregoing, and cannot be denied, our principles being supposed.

1. So think Suarez {marg. *Suarez. / Hurtadus. / Lugo. / Salmeron. / Valentia.*}, disp. v, sect. 8, num. xii, and disp. x, sect. 5; Hurtadus, disp. xxvii, throughout the whole; and Lugo, disp. i, sect. 13, § 5; with Salmerone, Valentia, Albertino, and other writers of our Society; against Turrecrematum, Cajetanum, Bannez, Canum, Vegam, Cordubam, Castrum, and others alleged by them. In these authors may be seen many other a posteriori arguments, which confirm and illustrate our asserted corollary, and all the objections that assail it resolved. For it has pleased us only to weigh the a priori reason knit to the doctrine which we grounded in the foregoing, and to open our mind at the first opportunity, and by an inference of the doctrine.